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Introduction

The global freelancing and gig-economy has expanded significantly in recent years as businesses increasingly outsource project-based work to independent contractors through online platforms. The global freelancing workforce stands at 1.57 billion people out of a total workforce of 3.38 billion, representing 46.6% of all workers worldwide as of 2025. The freelance platform market reached $7.65 billion in 2025 and is projected to grow at a CAGR of 16.66% to reach $16.54 billion by 2030 (Quantumrun Foresight, 2025).

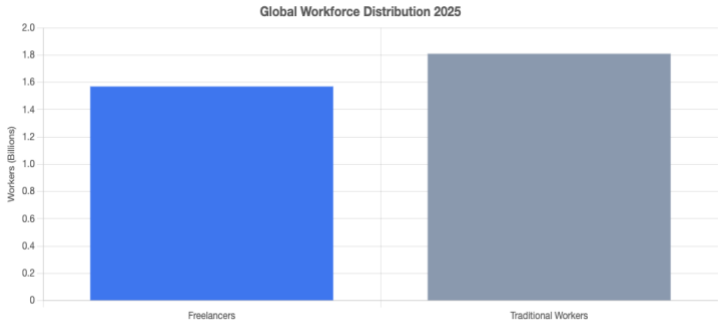

Figure 1: Global Workforce Distribution 2025 (Quantumrun Foresight, 2025).

For countries like Nepal, the expansion of the gig economy presents an opportunity to tap into global demand. Indeed, a study on Nepal's evolving employment dynamics reveals that the gig economy is becoming a visible feature of the Nepal market, especially for youth, urban professionals, and those seeking flexible work arrangements. Currently contributing approximately 6 percent to the national GDP (Ministry of Federal Affairs and General Administration, 2025).

Furthermore, there has been a sharp rise in Nepal's digital services export and freelancing work. Between 2017 and 2022, the number of registered freelancers reportedly rose from around 27,560 to 66,509 — reflecting growing interest in freelancing as a viable career path (Khanal, 2024). This rapid growth underscores a shift in Nepal's employment landscape and suggests that demand for skilled freelance services is increasing, both domestically and internationally.

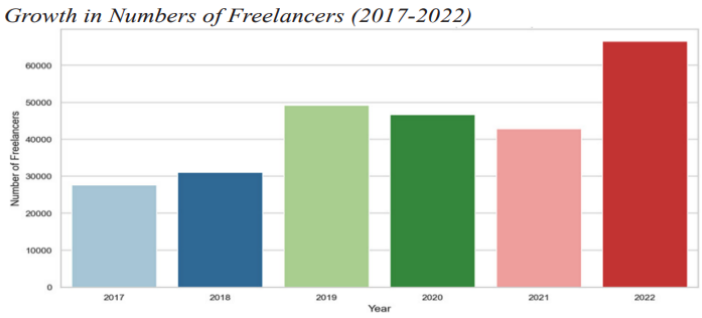

Figure 2: Growth in Numbers of Freelancers (2017 - 2022) (Khanal, 2024).

1.1. Problem scenario

Despite this growth, significant structural challenges remain that hinder the full potential of a local freelancing marketplace tailored for Nepal. Some key problems are:

- **Lack of organized, Nepal-centric platforms:** While many Nepali freelancers engage in global platforms, there is no well-developed Nepal-based platform that integrates discovery, trust, verification, and local regulatory/tax needs — a gap that limits accessibility, especially for newcomers or those less familiar with international freelancing norms. Academic studies on Nepal's gig economy note that although freelancing has the highest participation rate among gig sectors remain dominant, and long-term sustainability and worker protections are weak (Sagar B.K., 2024).
- **Informal structure, legal and social protection gaps:** According to a 2025 review on Nepal's gig economy, many gig workers (including freelancers) operate in a legal grey area: labour laws and social protection mechanisms do not adequately cover gig workers, leaving them without standard employment benefits, job security or social safety nets (Tuladhar, 2025). This lack of formal structure discourages many from committing to freelancing full-time.
- **High entry friction and inefficiencies in onboarding and matching:** New freelancers often struggle with manual profile creation, lack of verification,

unclear trust signals, and difficulty in finding suitable clients. These friction points make it harder for newcomers to compete and earn consistently, especially compared with established international platforms. As noted by Nepalese labour-economy analyses, participation often depends on prior employment status and satisfaction — people already under formal employment are more likely to engage in gig jobs, indicating barriers for fully new freelancers (Sagar B.K., 2024).

- **Challenges around payment mechanisms and global freelancing payments for Nepalese:** Nepali freelancers working for international clients often face difficulties receiving payments, due to lack of payment gateways, non-availability of services like FonePay, regulatory barriers, foreign-exchange hassles, and tax/compliance uncertainty. This increases friction, discourages participation, and reduces the appeal of freelancing as a stable income stream. Recent Nepali analyses highlight these as major drawbacks (Tuladhar, 2025).

1.2. The Project as a Solution — Worklynk

To address the above challenges, I proposed a startup-based freelancing platform called Worklynk, which considers the needs and demands of the Nepal-based freelancers and clients. The design of Worklynk will include:

- Low Barriers to Entry: The platform does not require any form of log-in prior to being able to browse projects and freelancers, which lowers the entry barrier to the platform that would allow potential clients and freelancers to learn about the platform and available opportunities.
- Simple but role-based Onboard: During registration, users choose a role (freelancer or client) with limited information (email, password). It allows posting of a project or applying to be done only with comprehensive profile completion and identity verification (e.g., PAN/VAT), thus refraining from too much accountability.
- Checklist-Gated Programs Staged Proposals: Freelancers are required to fill out certain checklists to be eligible to apply to a project and the qualified

applications would be minimal in order to increase the chances of hiring someone.

- Embedded Contract and Project Management: When one hires a contract is uploaded and the execution of the project follows a built-in pipeline interface (like Trello), which integrates the marketplace with management solutions to remove the external coordination.
- Trust & Reputation System: At the end of the project and payment, clients and freelancers evaluate one another. This creates a discoverable reputation history which drives high performance and creates trust.
- Flexible Modular Architecture of the future: The platform follows a modular platform. Though the first version is based on the core matching and project management, the architecture is planned with payment gateways, escrow, invoicing, and tax modules, which will be integrated smoothly in the future to expand the business to financial services.
- Planned Automated Profiling: To further automate the onboarding process, in a later release we will introduce automated CV/ resume parsing, where skills and experience are automatically extracted out of the uploaded documents to remove the bottleneck of creating a profile manually.

1.3. Why Worklynk is Valuable for Nepal

Worklynk will specifically respond to the specific opportunities and challenges of the emerging freelance economy in Nepal and value will be generated to all the participants.

- Accesses a Fast-Maturing Market: Worklynk will take advantage of the fact that Nepalis are interested in freelancing in significant numbers and their numbers have increased dramatically since 2017, when the number of Nepali freelancers was about 27,500, to over 66,500 in 2022 (Khanal, 2024). The platform is a specific local channel through which this growing pool of talent can be directed.
- Closes a Significant Structural Vacuity: Gig economy in Nepal does not have any formalization and streamlined platforms at present (Ministry of

Federal Affairs and General Administration, 2025). Worklynk addresses this specific need directly by establishing a secure, open, and organized ecosystem, which prioritizes local conformity and user safety, which is a critical gap in the market.

- Makes access democratic and encourages inclusiveness: Worklynk actively seeks to attract younger users, fresh graduates, and rural freelancers, by reducing entry barriers, including the ability to look through projects without an account, and a straightforward entry signup. The approach works in democratizing the economic prospects other than the conventional urban professional centers.
- Improves Productivity and develops Trust: Worklynk is also designed to enhance the whole freelancing lifecycle. The platform mitigates mismatches and onboarding on the platform through features such as checklist-gated applications and inbuilt project management tools. This translates to increased success rates of projects and hence trust is created and repeat involvement to the platform is promoted.
- Establishes a Platform of Full-Cycle Freelance Economy: The site has a modular design, which is a strategic future investment in the freelance in Nepal. It offers a scalable infrastructure to add important services such as payment processing, escrow, and contract enforcement, which are significant issues of concern to the Nepalis dealing with local and foreign consumers.

Considering the spread of the freelance/gig economy around the world and in Nepal in particular and obvious structural gaps in existing applications, there is a strong incentive to consider a well-developed, Nepal-specific platform. The solution proposed by Worklynk will help to bridge this gap by providing a full package of solutions, i.e. discovery and onboarding, project execution and trust building, and thus allow freelancers and clients in Nepal to communicate effectively, safely, and equitably. This contributes to the fact that the proposed project is not only timely, but also socially and economically applicable in the environment of the changing labour market in Nepal.

Aims and Objectives

The main aim of this project is to design and develop Worklynk, which is a Nepal-focused freelancing platform that facilitates the interaction between clients and their freelancers by optimally discovering projects, facilitating the hiring processes, verifying, and developing profiles, creating project-management pipelines, and executing contracts with trust in place to fill the existing gaps in the Nepal-driven freelance ecosystem.

2.1. Academic/Research & Documentation Objectives (appendix see more)

These objectives align with academic requirements such as analysis, documentation, SDLC deliverables, and theoretical justification.

- To conduct a detailed analysis of Nepal's freelance ecosystem, including platform gaps, user pain-points, trust barriers, and regulatory challenges supported by credible research and evidence.
- To model the system requirements formally by producing complete Software Requirement Specification (SRS), including functional requirements, non-functional requirements, use-case models, and dataflow/process diagrams.
- To design a structured database and system architecture using appropriate design methodologies (ER diagrams, normalized schema, modular service architecture, workflow diagrams).
- To evaluate and justify an appropriate SDLC methodology suitable for developing a multi-role freelancing platform with phased deliverables.
- To develop and document system prototypes (low-fidelity and high-fidelity wireframes) for validating user flows such as onboarding, project browsing, bidding, contract execution, and project management pipeline.
- To produce complete project documentation, including SRS, SDS (Software Design Specification) (UML diagrams), test cases, test reports.

2.2. System/Functional Objectives (Appendix see more click)

These objectives relate to the actual implementation and features of the Worklynk system.

- To develop a public access browsing system that allows users to view freelancers and projects without authentication.
- To implement a two-role user onboarding flow (Freelancer / Client) with minimal sign-up and extended profile completion triggered only when posting or applying for a project.
- To integrate PAN/VAT verification into the profile-completion workflow to increase trust and legitimacy among clients and freelancers.
- To implement a CV-Upload system with automated parsing (PDF extraction of skills, experience, education, and relevant data) to reduce onboarding friction and improve profile quality. (If not in MVP, move to future enhancement but still counted as an objective.)
- To design and develop a project-posting module with detailed requirement listings, checklists, milestones, budget range, and delivery timeline.
- To implement structured bidding and proposal submission, allowing freelancers to apply only if they meet all checklist items and upload a proposal document (PDF).
- To design an integrated real-time communication system (chat module) for freelancer–client interaction before contract finalization. (Priority feature; fallback to message-based communication if real-time is future enhancement.)
- To create a contract system, where clients and freelancers finalize terms (pricing, schedule, payment plan, deliverables) and store it securely.
- To integrate project-management board, enabling task creation, assignment, progress tracking (To-Do → In-Progress → Review → Done).
- To implement a rating and feedback mechanism after contract completion and final delivery to build trust and marketplace transparency.

- To ensure system security, reliability, and usability, applying authentication, authorization, input-validation, secure file handling, and UX-focused design.

Expected Outcomes and Deliverables

This section is the description of the practical outcomes and concrete deliverables of the Worklynk project. Project Deliverables are specific items that will be provided to be assessed, whereas Expected Outcomes are the reflection of the final product in terms of its impact and core functionalities.

3.1. Expected Outcomes

1. The Nepal-based freelancing platform (Worklynk) that allows:
    - Surfing freelancers and projects.
    - Role based onboarding.
    - structured project posting
    - Checklist-based bidding
    - Proposal uploads
    - Contract management
    - Project management pipeline
    - Rating and review system
2. Better trust, transparency and efficiency of the freelancer-client relationships through integration of verification and systematic workflows.
3. Full digital process of the discovery/hiring/contract/project execution/completion, and thus freelance work becomes more structured in Nepalese context.
4. An architectureable system architecture with the ability to be scaled and scaled in the future with the addition of cv parsing and secure payment.

3.2. Project Deliverables

1. System Deliverables
    - Worklynk MVP Web-based application is fully functional.
    - Admin control board of the user management and the verification and moderation of the project.

    - Services (APIs, authentication, project workflows, parsing logic).
    - Database schema and database implemented.
2. Documentation Deliverables
    - Project Proposal (as of today).
    - Software Requirement Specification (SRS).
    - Software Design Document (SDS) - contains UML diagrams, architecture, interfaces, design of data structure.
    - Work Breakdown Structure (WBS).
    - Gantt Chart with milestones.
    - Test Case Documents and Test Plan.
    - Final Report / Dissertation Incorporating analysis, design, implementation, testing, evaluation, and conclusion.
3. Presentation Deliverables
    - Last line of defence presentation and demonstration of the system.

Project risks, threats and contingency plans

Risk / Threat	Description	Impact	Likelihood	Mitigation plan / Contingency
Scope Creep / Feature Overload	Introduction of unnecessary features (e.g., real-time chat, payment) that are not in the MVP scope.	High	Medium	Strict following of MVP feature list. The backlog contains a Future Enhancements list, and new feature requests will always be placed in it.
Technical Integration Problems	Difficulty with integrating fundamental	Medium	Medium	Modular creation in accordance with Agile principles. The modules will

	modules such as project management pipeline or role-based dashboards.			be subdivided, developed and tested gradually to identify and fix problems early.
Inaccessibility of PAN/VAT API	Not having an effective public API in Nepal to perform automated identity verification.	High	High	Primary Mitigation: Implement a manual verification process where users submit their documents to the admin who verifies them and changes their status to "Verified".
Risks of Time Management	The workload of FYP and personal deadlines leading to slippage of the timeline.	High	Medium	Strict compliance to the Work Breakdown Structure (WBS) and Gantt chart. Progress meetings will be conducted weekly to monitor milestones and change plans dynamically.
Data Loss / System Crash	Failure of local development environment or corruption of database.	High	Low	Version control using Git with frequent pushes to a remote repository (GitHub). The database will be backed up automatically on a regular basis.
Security & Authentication Flaws	Weaknesses that result in unauthorized access or	High	Low	Implement industry-standard authentication (e.g., JWT), strict input validation.

	information leakage.			
Data Extraction Inaccuracy (CV Parsing)	PDF parsing errors caused by inconsistent document formats.	Medium	Medium	Use a hybrid approach: the system will attempt parsing, but a mandatory manual form will serve as a backup to ensure data completeness.
Performance Problems	Slow system response, especially for searches and filtering as data volume grows.	Medium	Medium	Proactive database optimization, including indexing. Performance testing with sample data; caching identified as a future optimization.
Reliance on Third-Party Libraries	Important libraries for UI or parsing becoming obsolete or creating incompatibilities.	Medium	Medium	Selection of widely adopted stable libraries. Dependency versions will be pinned, and alternative libraries have been identified for essential components.
Testing/QA Limitations	Untested edge cases due to system complexity.	Medium	Medium	Execute a comprehensive test plan covering unit, integration, and system testing. All tests and results will be formally documented.

Table 1: Project risks, threats and contigency plans.

Methodology

An appropriate Software Development Life Cycle (SDLC) process is a necessity in terms of organized development, foreseeable results, and quality work. In the case of Worklynk, three approaches were considered Scrum, Waterfall, and Hybrid Agile-Waterfall. When considering the scope of the project, academic needs, documentation amount of work, and anticipated iterative development, Hybrid Agile-Waterfall model is chosen as the proposed methodology.

5.1. Considered Methodologies (Appendix)

5.1.1. Waterfall model:

The Waterfall model is a linear, sequential approach to the software development lifecycle (SDLC) that's popular in software engineering and product development. It uses a logical progression of SDLC steps for a project, similar to the direction water flows over the edge of a cliff. It sets distinct endpoints or goals for each phase of the development process. Those endpoints or goals can't be revisited after their completion (Kirvan, 2024).

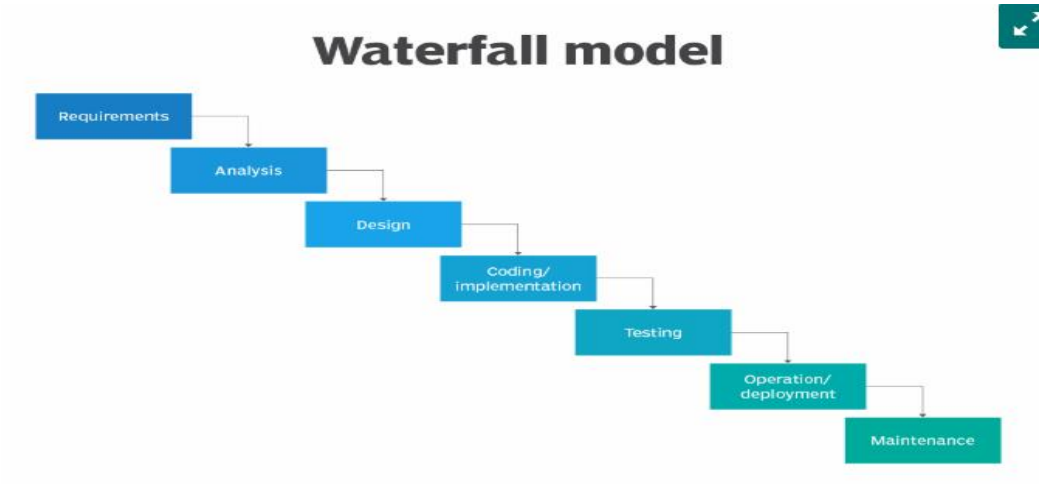

Figure 3: Waterfall Model (Kirvan, 2024).

Consideration Justification: The Waterfall model was viewed as a possibility since the focus on detailed and upfront documentation and a

strict and stepwise nature of the form work well with the explicit deliverables and the submissions in stages that the FYP model demands.

Reason for Rejection

The Waterfall model was viewed as a possibility since the focus on detailed and upfront documentation and a strict and stepwise nature of the form work well with the explicit deliverables and the submissions in stages that the FYP model demands.

- **Lack of Flexibility to Refinement:** The functionality of Worklynk like the Kanban like project board and the bidding module should undergo iterative refinement with prototyping and testing. The strict nature of the Waterfall design is very expensive and hard to integrate such feedback once the design is finished.
- **Late-Risk Discovery:** Testing between the system as a whole is done after the system is complete. This exposes the project to the occurrence of major integration or architecture failures towards the end of the project schedule with a high risk of failure within the academic time frame.
- **No Working Increments:** This model does not generate a working product until the very end, and thus does not provide a chance to verify core functionalities and demos to conduct initial assessments.

5.1.2. Scrum (Agile Framework)

Scrum is an Agile project management framework that helps teams organize and oversee their work through values, principles, and practices. Scrum encourages teams to learn through experience, self-organize while working on a problem, and reflect on their successes and failures to continuously improve (Drumond, 2025).

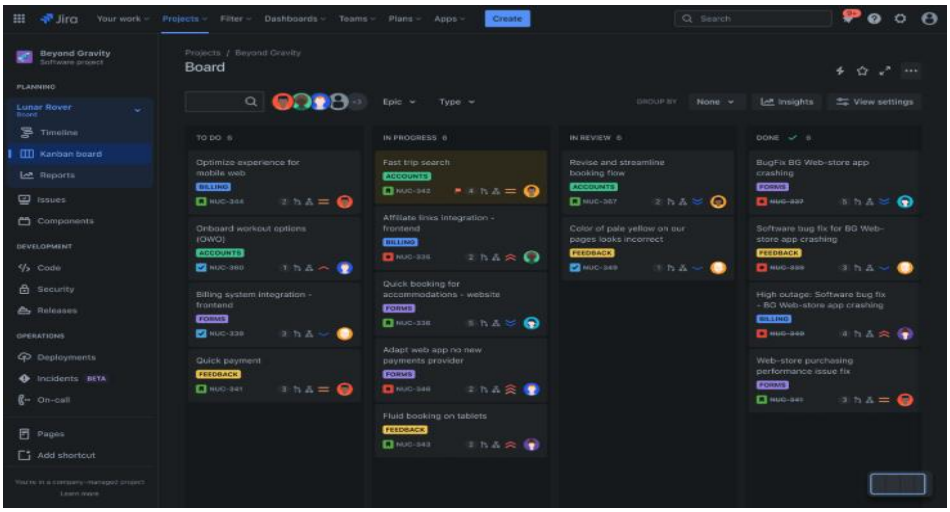

Figure 4: Kanban Board. (Drumond, 2025)

Consideration Justification: The application of Scrum was deemed appropriate because the system is complex and needs to be iterated to provide a fast and frequent feedback. It is best suited to projects whose requirements are likely to change dynamically, which is consistent with the possibility of refining the features of Worklynk.

Rationale for Rejection (Appendix)

In spite of its advantages, Scrum is not the best solution to this Final Year Project because of the following reasons:

- Conflict with Upfront Documentation Requirements: The FYP requires the presentation of full documentation prior to the main development stage, which includes full Software Requirements Specification (SRS), UML diagrams, and ERDs. The requirement that Scrum employs is in direct opposition to the need of definite and upfront deliverables.
- Unrealistic Team-Based Organization Scrum is intended to work with teammates who have specific roles (Scrum Master, Product Owner). As an individual developer, it is not feasible to simulate such roles

and hold daily stand-ups, which do not provide the administrative overhead with the desired collaborative value.

- The inflexibility of the checkpoint deliverables of an FYP (proposal, SRS, final report) needs a consistent scope and known deliverables, which is incompatible with the Scrum-flexible backlog and adaptive scope.

5.2. Proposed Methodology: Hybrid Agile-Waterfall Model

Agile Waterfall Hybrid is a midway approach to Agile and Waterfall methods, which make use of the benefits of both methodologies. Since the agile and waterfall methodologies have their pros and cons, ruling out one in favour of the other would not be a sensible approach. There has been a significant growth in the trend of using this hybrid agile methodology for a lot of reasons (Aims, 2025).

Proposed Process Summary

Phase 1: Waterfall (Structured Planning and Design):

- RS Creation and Requirement Analysis.
- System Design (UML, ERD, Architecture Diagrams)
- Output: Finished, satisfactory documentation according to the FYP.

Phase 2 - Agile (Iterative Development and Testing):

- Sprint 1: User Authentication and Public Browsing.
- Sprint 2: Management and verification of profile.
- Sprint 3: Project Posting and Bidding Module.
- Sprint 4: Kanban Board and Contract Management.
- Sprint 5: Rating System, Admin Dashboard.
- Deliverable: A complete tested platform that is developed on controllable bits.

Justification as the Ideal Fit

- Hybrid model is the best option to be chosen to work on the Worklynk project due to the following reasons:
- Meets Academic Requirements: The first stage of the Waterfall phase is a guarantee that all the required documentation (SRS, SDS, diagrams) is done and finalized in advance, which fits the FYP submission requirements perfectly.
- Facilitates Adaptive Development: The following Agile sprints permit the iterating construction, integrating, and testing of complicated modules. This approach helps to reduce the technical risks at early stages and enables the practical refinement of the features without contravening the pre-established project scope.
- Best used in Solo Development: It has a well-organized roadmap to adhere to and yet flexible enough in implementation without the burdensome task of simulating a complete Scrum team.
- Favors an MVP-Centric Strategy: It is a model that helps to focus on the creation of the core Minimum Viable Product (MVP). The optional advanced features, like more sophisticated CV parsing, can either be put to the backlog and implemented much later, provided time permits, or duly prioritized and implemented.

Resource Requirements

6.1. Hardware Resources

Resource	Description & Justification
Laptop/PC (i5/i7, 8–16GB RAM)	Required for running development servers, databases, IDEs, and testing multiple modules concurrently.
Smartphone (Android/iOS)	Needed for mobile responsiveness testing and prototype validation.
Storage (SSD 256GB+)	For storing project files, datasets, dependencies, and backups.

Table 2: Hardware Resources.

6.2. Software Resources

Software	Description & Importance
VS Code	Primary development environment for frontend & backend coding, debugging, and version control integration.
Node.js + Express.js	Backend runtime and framework for building RESTful APIs, authentication, and business logic.
NextJS	Frontend framework for building dynamic and responsive user interfaces and dashboards built on top of React.
PostgreSQL	NoSQL database for storing flexible data models like user profiles, projects, and contracts.
Git & GitHub	Version control system for tracking code changes, collaboration, and project backup.

Docker	Containerization platform for consistent development and deployment environments (optional for future scaling).
Postman	API testing tool for debugging endpoints and ensuring backend functionality.
Figma	UI/UX design tool for creating wireframes, prototypes, and visual designs before implementation.

Table 3: Software Resources.

6.3. External Access/Services

- Availability of PAN/VAT verification protocols of IRD Nepal (manual or API-based).
- Access to Nepal Rastra Bank policies to learn the limitation of payment (to improve in the future).

Work Breakdown Structure

A WBS is a project management tool used in visual representation and partitions a project into smaller manageable and structured components in a hierarchical manner. It begins with the general objective on the top and breaks the project down into small tasks and deliverables. The levels are inter-relational as each level is linked to the levels above it and how the single tasks benefit the bigger deliverable. Such a hierarchical perspective assists a team to plan, administer, and track intricate work more efficiently (Figma, 2025).

Projects in a WBS are organized in three levels:

- Level one is one that indicates the whole project or ultimate deliverable and gives a high description of the purpose of the project.
- The middle level, level two, divides the project into significant deliverables or phases that should be fulfilled to accomplish the key objective.

- Level three and further lower levels will subdivide each deliverable into finer tasks and work packages of each individual or team.

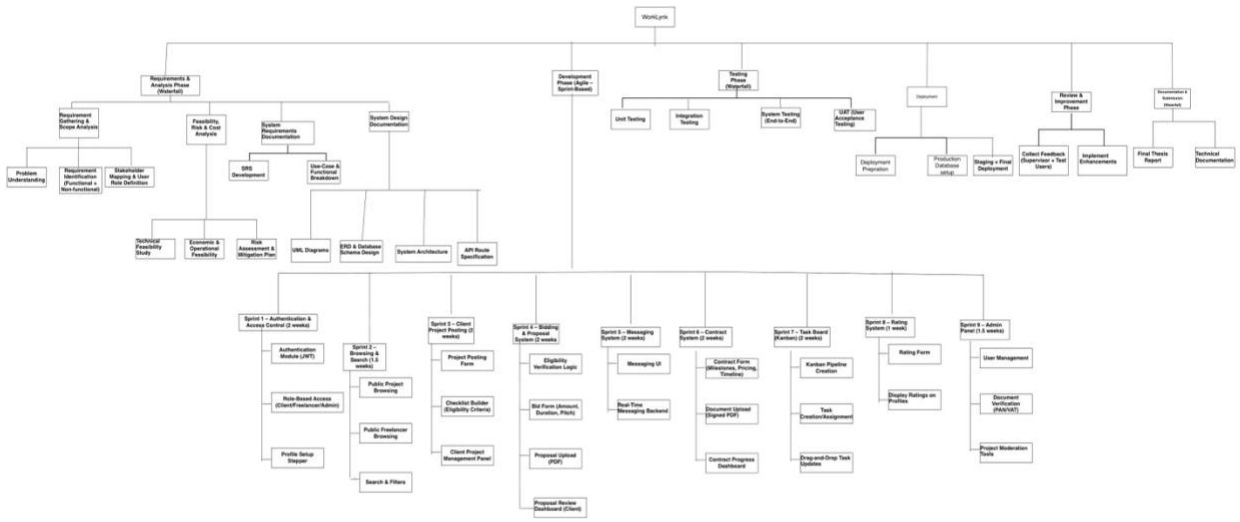

Figure 5: WBS.

Milestones

A milestone chart is a horizontal chart that marks the most important steps of your project. Each milestone your team achieves brings you closer to completing the project. Besides keeping your team motivated, a milestone chart is also a great way to show project stakeholders how your project is progressing. In this article, we cover how to create a milestone chart and how you can use it to celebrate milestones with your team (Asana, 2025).

For this project, milestones are aligned with the Hybrid Agile–Waterfall methodology, ensuring that Waterfall-driven documentation phases and Agile-driven sprint cycles are monitored effectively.

Each milestone below corresponds to the completion of a major set of activities from the WBS and marks a clear deliverable or phase transition.

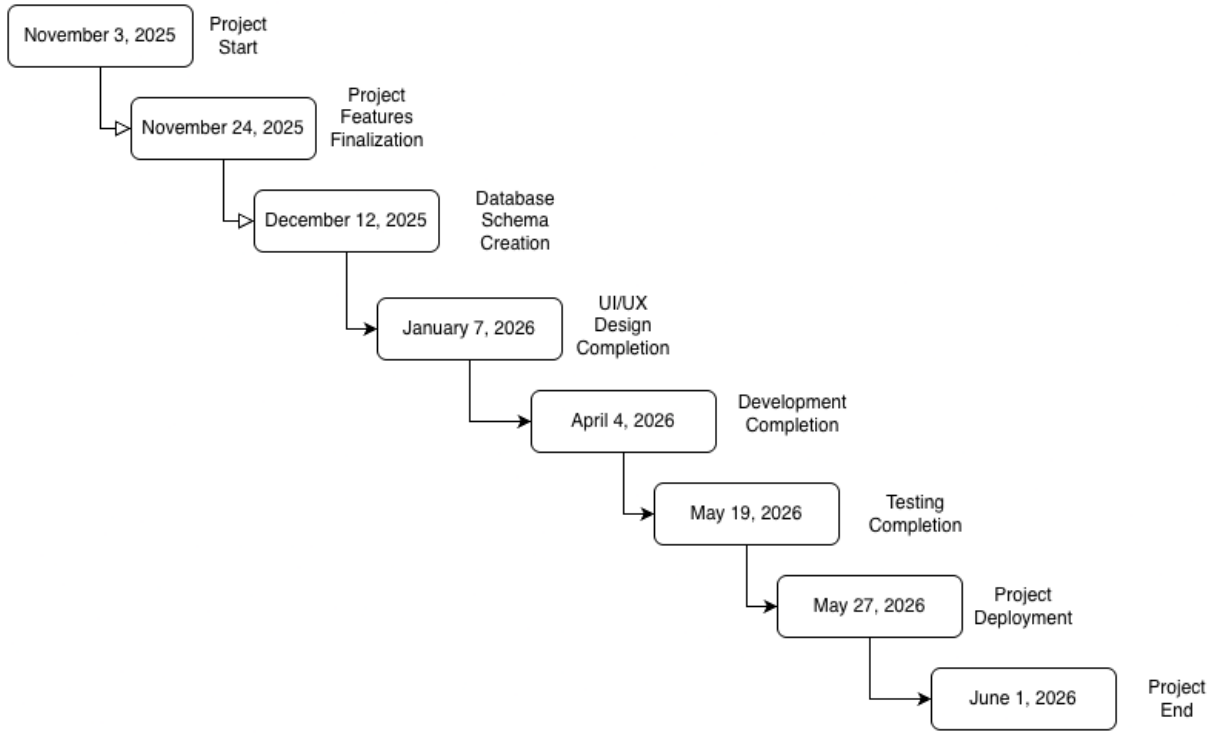

Figure 6: Milestone Chart.

Project Gantt Chart

A Gantt chart, commonly used in project management, is one of the most popular and useful ways of showing activities (tasks or events) displayed against time. On the left of the chart is a list of the activities and along the top is a suitable time scale. Each activity is represented by a bar; the position and length of the bar reflects the start date, duration and end date of the activity (Gantt, 2025).

See Gantt Chart.

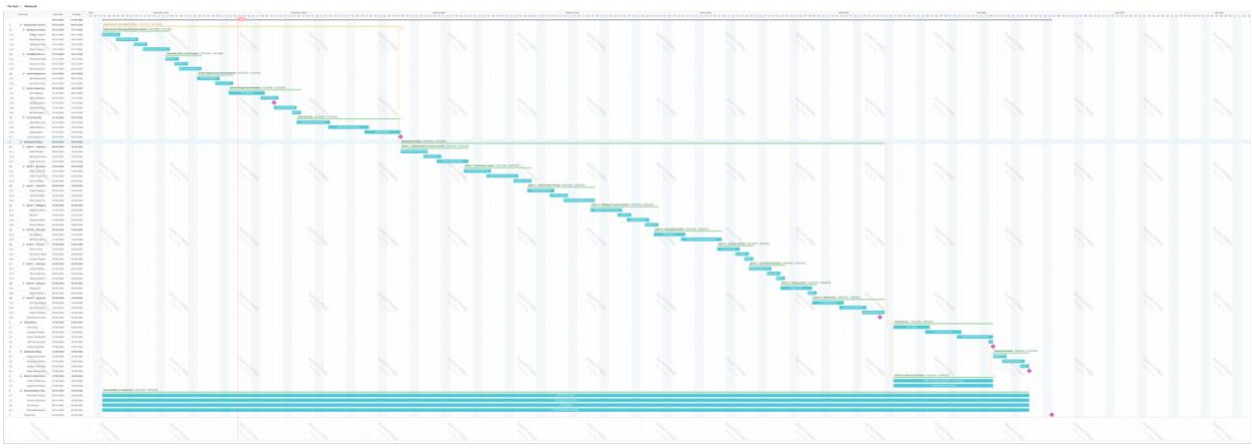

Figure 7: Gantt Chart.

Conclusion

Worklynk is the proposed project that is designed to fill an essential gap in the freelancing and project-based work environment in Nepal by introducing a centralized, structured, and verification-centered platform. The proposal gives a solid background on why a comprehensive solution is required through the thorough examination of the current issues that include fragmented service channels, no trusted relations between clients and freelancers, and the unstructured flow of services through project posting to the ultimate delivery. All the identified goals, objectives, and anticipated outcomes prove that Worklynk will not just facilitate the process of effective project matchmaking but also bring about professional standards due to such functionality as PAN/VAT checks, structured bidding, contractual agreements, Kanban-style task management, and built-in rating systems.

The selected Hybrid methodology of Agile-Waterfall would provide a systematic yet flexible development approach that would be compliant with academic norms of initial documentation upfront but allows the iterative development of the procedure through sprints. The Work Breakdown Structure, milestones, and Gantt-aligned roadmap support the possibility of delivering the project on time within the academic time-period even more. The determination of identified risks and contingency plans also points to the preparedness of the project to real challenges in the world during the implementation.

In general, the proposal is a clear, well-informed, and implementable concept of the development of a powerful freelancing and project management platform, which would suit the conditions in Nepal. On successful completion, Worklynk is supposed to provide a high-value digital solution, which will improve trust, transparency, and efficiency in the digital employment industry-increasing Nepal, and meet all the academic, technical, and operational needs of the Final Year Project.

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